Lesson 08: From Moral Principles to Ethics Codes

English Stage 4 (Psychology) · Unit 2: Research Ethics and Measurement

Adapted from Research Methods in Psychology (4th American edition) by Rajiv S. Jhangiani, I-Chant A. Chiang, Carrie Cuttler and Dana C. Leighton (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0): 3.3 From Moral Principles to Ethics Codes.

In this lesson

You follow the history of research ethics codes, from the Nuremberg Code to institutional review boards, and study Standard 8 of the APA Ethics Code (informed consent, deception, debriefing, animal research and scholarly integrity). You practise the language of rules and three ways of defining a term.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Outline the history of ethics codes for research with human participants.
- Explain what an IRB does and the three levels of risk in US federal regulations.
- Apply the main parts of APA Standard 8 to research situations.
- Write rules in the style of an ethics code and define terms in three ways.

Key language

Term or phrase	Meaning	Example
Nuremberg Code	10 principles written in 1947 in conjunction with the trials of Nazi physicians	It was particularly clear about the need for informed consent.
protocol	A detailed written description of a research project that an independent committee can review for its conformity to ethical standards.	Research should be based on a written protocol.
beneficence	maximizing the benefits of research while minimizing harms to participants and society	one of the three principles of the Belmont Report
institutional review board (IRB)	A committee at a university, hospital or other institution that reviews research protocols to be sure they conform to ethical standards.	An IRB must consist of at least five people.
minimal risk	risks no greater than those met by healthy people in daily life or routine physical or psychological examinations; greater risk is "at-risk research"	Expedited research is no greater than minimal risk.
APA Ethics Code	The ethics code of the American Psychological Association; Standard 8 concerns research and publication.	It includes about 150 specific standards.

Term or phrase	Meaning	Example
consent form	A form that participants sign, describing the procedure, risks and benefits, the right to withdraw and any confidentiality issues.	Many participants do not actually read consent forms.
plagiarism	using others' words or ideas without proper acknowledgment	Proper acknowledgment means quotation marks and a citation.
self-plagiarism	publishing the same material more than once	Self-plagiarism is also considered unethical.
in conjunction with	together with; at the same time as	written in conjunction with the trials
provided that	only if (a condition)	… provided that the confidentiality of the participants can be protected

Rules and explanations

The ideas

Why codes? People who agree on the moral principles of Lesson 07 still disagree about specific issues, so detailed, enforceable codes give guidance on frequent issues.

Code	Year	Main contribution
Nuremberg Code	1947	Written for the trials of Nazi physicians; clear on weighing risks against benefits and on informed consent.
Declaration of Helsinki	1964	Research should follow a written **protocol** reviewed by an independent committee.
Belmont Report	1978	After Tuskegee: **justice** (fair distribution of risks and benefits across groups), **respect for persons** (autonomy, and protection for people with diminished autonomy such as prisoners and children, hence informed consent) and **beneficence**.
Federal Policy for the Protection of Human Subjects	after 1978	Laws based on the Belmont Report; institutions with federal support must have an IRB.

IRBs have at least five members with varying backgrounds: different professions, scientists and nonscientists, men and women, and at least one person not otherwise affiliated with the institution. They check that risks are minimized, benefits outweigh risks, the research is fair and the consent procedure is adequate.

Level of risk	What it covers	Review
Exempt	normal educational activities; standard measures and nonsensitive surveys given confidentially; existing public data	once approved, no regular, continuous review
Expedited	no greater than minimal risk	one IRB member, or a committee that can approve only minimal-risk research
Greater than minimal risk	everything else	the full board

The APA Ethics Code (first published 1953) has about 150 standards, many about clinical practice. Standard 8 covers research:

Standards	Topic
8.01	institutional approval before the research
8.02-8.05	informed consent; 8.02a lists eight points: (1) purpose, duration and procedures; (2) the right to decline or withdraw; (3) the consequences of declining or withdrawing; (4) risks, discomfort or adverse effects; (5) benefits; (6) limits of confidentiality; (7) incentives; (8) whom to contact with questions
8.06	no excessive or inappropriate inducements that are likely to coerce participation
8.07-8.08	deception and debriefing
8.09	humane care and use of animals
8.10-8.15	scholarly integrity

Informed consent is a process, not just a signature. Many participants do not read or understand consent forms; some think that signing means giving up their right to sue (Mann, 1994). So explain the risks and benefits, demonstrate the procedure, invite questions and remind participants that they can withdraw at any time. Consent is not needed when research is not expected to cause harm and is straightforward or part of ordinary activities: observing whether people hold doors open, or an instructor comparing two legitimate teaching methods.

Deception includes misinforming participants about the purpose, confederates, phony equipment, false feedback, and withholding the full design or purpose (a "memory test" that asks about the room, not the words). Baumrind (1985) argued that it is rarely if ever justified: it prevents truly informed consent, fails to respect dignity, can upset participants, makes them distrustful and less honest, and damages researchers' reputation. The APA allows deception when the benefits outweigh the risks, participants cannot reasonably be expected to be harmed, the question cannot be answered without it, and participants are told as soon as possible. **Debriefing** then reveals the purpose and any deception, corrects misconceptions and minimizes harm (for example, a happy video after a sad-mood induction).

Nonhuman animals are used in a significant minority of studies. Critics note that animals cannot consent and can suffer (Bowd & Shapiro, 1993); supporters point to behavioral therapies, pain control,

antipsychotic drugs and benefits to animals (Miller, 1985). The APA accepts animal research when benefits outweigh costs, alternatives are used when possible and care is humane.

Scholarly integrity: no fabrication, plagiarism or self-plagiarism; no republishing old data as new; share data; keep reviewed manuscripts confidential; author order reflects each person's contribution.

Notes on the printed material. (1) In the printed Standard 8, sub-standards appear as numbers ("3.", "4." ...) instead of letters; in the Code they are (a), (b), so "8.02a" is the list of eight points. (2) The Declaration of Helsinki was adopted by the World Medical Association (the book says "Council") and has been revised again since 2004. (3) The APA Ethics Code was amended again in 2016.

Language focus

1. The language of rules. The APA Code states obligations in the **present simple**, not with *must*, and limits permission with *only* (and conditions such as *unless* and *provided that*):

- "Psychologists **do not fabricate** data." (8.10)
- "Psychologists **may** dispense with informed consent **only** (1) where ..." (8.05)

2. Three ways to define a term.

- A dash phrase: "a written **protocol**—a detailed description of the research—that is reviewed by an independent committee"
- *means / refers to*: "**Plagiarism means** using others' words or ideas without proper acknowledgment."
- *is called ... because*: "It **is called** exempt **because** once approved, it is exempt from regular, continuous review."

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - After *must*, *may* and *should*, use the base verb: "must obtain", not "must to obtain" or "must obtains". - Names of codes take *the* (*the* Nuremberg Code, *the* Belmont Report); numbered parts do not (Standard 8.07).

Practice

1. Reading questions (section 3.3)

1. Why do detailed, enforceable codes exist if almost everyone agrees on the general principles?
2. What did the Declaration of Helsinki add to the Nuremberg Code?
3. What three principles did the Belmont Report recognize, and what does each mean?
4. Who must sit on an IRB?
5. Which kinds of research can be exempt, and why is it called "exempt"?
6. Why is a signed consent form not always enough, and what is good practice?
7. Under what four conditions does the APA Ethics Code allow deception?

2. Applying Standard 8 (section 3.3 has no exercises; the chapter's exercises are in Lesson 09) A. Which standard applies? Is the action acceptable? If not, what should the researcher do?

1. A researcher wants to video-record participants during a laboratory interview.
2. Psychology students must take part in a study to receive course credit.
3. A researcher records whether people hold the door open at a public building.
4. Participants are told they did poorly on a test when they actually did well, and nobody tells them the truth afterwards.
5. A researcher discovers a significant error in her published data.
6. A department chair who did no work on a study asks to be an author.

B. Discussion: Is Baumrind's view (deception is rarely if ever justified) or the APA's "more moderate approach" more convincing? (about 100 words)

3. Language A. Rewrite in the style of the APA Code (present simple, beginning "Psychologists ...").

1. Researchers must not present portions of another's work as their own.
2. Researchers must get institutional approval before they conduct the research.

B. Write a definition with the pattern given, using section 3.3.

1. beneficence (*means*)
2. the Nuremberg Code (dash phrase)

Speak with your tutor

- "Let me tell the story from the Nuremberg Code to IRBs in two minutes. Correct my facts and my English."
- "In PSYC 110 Lecture 9 (Love), Professor Salovey describes Aronson's 'Frizzy Wig' experiment, in which a confederate gave men a favourable or unfavourable personality evaluation. Which kinds of deception did it use, and what would Standard 8.07 require today?"
- "In PSYC 110 Lecture 15 (Morality), Professor Bloom describes chimpanzee studies in which getting food meant giving another chimpanzee a painful shock, and says they 'would be unethical if they were to be done today'. Help me explain why, using Standard 8.09."
- "Here is my sleep and memory study. Ask me questions until we decide whether it is exempt, expedited or full-board research."

Writing task

Continue the ethics section of your proposal: apply the APA Ethics Code to your study (200-300 words).

- The level of IRB review you expect, and why (a survey of students' usual sleep differs from a study in which, after learning 40 word pairs, they have a nap opportunity of up to 90 minutes or rest quietly awake for the same time).
- The points of 8.02a that need most care (for example, tiredness, limits of confidentiality).
- If participants earn course credit, the alternative activity (8.04b).

- Deception: if participants are not told that they will be tested on what they learn, this is like the book's incidental learning example. Are the 8.07 conditions met? When will you reveal it (8.08)?
- Cite standards in parentheses, for example "(APA Standard 8.07)"; use *will* for your plans and one dash definition.

If you work on your own topic, apply the same standards to your study.

Self-editing checklist:

- Did I justify the level of review with the book's definitions?
- Did I mention at least four of the eight points in 8.02a?
- Did I deal with course credit and inducements, if relevant?
- Is any deception justified under all four conditions?
- Did I cite each standard by its number?
- Did I use the base verb after modals?

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Watch online

- The full APA Ethics Code: https://www.apa.org/ethics/code
- The Nuremberg Code, the Declaration of Helsinki, the Belmont Report and the Federal Policy (US Office for Human Research Protections): https://www.hhs.gov/ohrp/international/ethical-codes-and-research-standards/index.html
- The APA Committee on Animal Research and Ethics: https://www.apa.org/science/leadership/care/index.aspx

Answer key

1. Reading questions

1. People who agree on the principles can still disagree about specific issues, so detailed codes give guidance on issues that arise frequently.
2. Research should be based on a written protocol reviewed by an independent committee.
3. Justice: risks and benefits distributed fairly across groups in society. Respect for persons: autonomy and protection for those with diminished autonomy, hence informed consent. Beneficence: maximizing benefits while minimizing harms.
4. At least five people: different professions, scientists and nonscientists, men and women, and at least one person not otherwise affiliated with the institution.
5. Research on normal educational activities; standard measures and nonsensitive surveys given confidentially; research with existing public data. Once approved, it is exempt from regular, continuous review.
6. Many participants do not read or understand consent forms, and some think signing means giving up their right to sue (Mann, 1994). Good practice: tell them the risks and benefits, demonstrate the procedure, ask for questions and remind them of their right to withdraw.
7. The benefits outweigh the risks; participants cannot reasonably be expected to be harmed; the question cannot be answered without deception; participants are told about it as soon as possible.

2. Applying Standard 8 A. 1. 8.03: acceptable with informed consent obtained before recording. 2. 8.04b: acceptable only if an equitable alternative activity is offered. 3. 8.05: acceptable without consent (observation of an ordinary activity, no harm expected). 4. 8.07c and 8.08: not acceptable; explain the deception as early as feasible (no later than the end of data collection), allow participants to withdraw their data and correct the misconception. 5. 8.10b: correct it (a correction, retraction or erratum). 6. 8.12: not acceptable; "mere possession of an institutional position, such as department chair, does not justify authorship credit". B. (example answer) The APA's moderate approach is more convincing. Baumrind is right that deception can upset participants and damage trust, but not all deception is equally bad: a slightly different "memory test" is very different from Milgram's procedure. Some important questions, such as when people help a stranger, cannot be answered if participants know the purpose. Provided that participants are not harmed and are debriefed promptly, mild deception seems justified. (Agreeing with Baumrind, with reasons, is also valid.)

3. Language A. 1. Psychologists do not present portions of another's work or data as their own (8.11). 2. Psychologists obtain institutional approval prior to conducting the research (8.01). B. (example answers) 1. Beneficence means maximizing the benefits of research while minimizing harms to participants and society. 2. The Nuremberg Code—a set of 10 principles written in 1947 in conjunction with the trials of Nazi physicians—stressed informed consent.

My notes